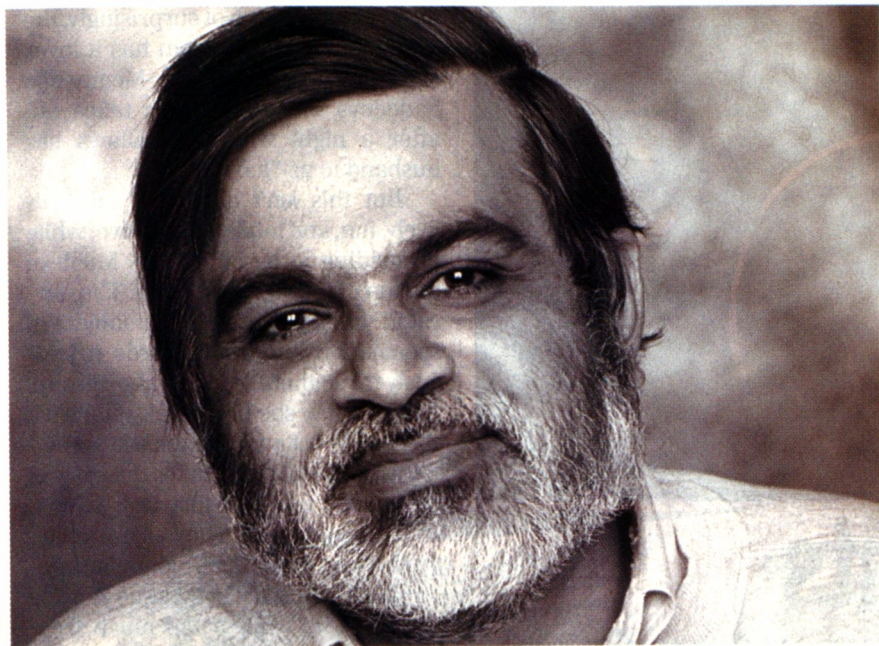




Tracing the Killer Gene

Vassanji's new novel is an elegiac journey into the labyrinths of history



THE ASSASSIN'S SONG

by M.G. VASSANJI

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■ By Geeta Doctor

M.G. Vassanji has lived long enough and far enough from his roots to be able to compose a grand elegy of mourning and meaning that speaks of India, when, in the words of Andre Malraux, it still had poetry running through its veins. Post Godhra, he is the Leon Uris of the Indian subcontinent, singing of the torment that her people have undergone, with a view to bringing about an understanding on why such things must happen.

The very name Gujarat, the people, the soft susurrations of their native tongue, the resurrection of the marvelous tales about Patan and its legendary kings that were collected in that compendium of wonders known as *Ras Mala*, *Hindoo Annals of the Province of Goozerat in Western India* by Alexander Kinloch Forbes in 1924, the texture of her cultural fabric that has been woven with the colours of many different tribes and traditions, invokes

in Vassanji a sense of both immeasurable pride and grief. This is the shehnai edition of Indian history, the grave thump of karmic destiny. Neither the playful, teasing triviality of the bamboo flute, nor the breathless beats of drum, dholak or ghatam are here to distract attention. Yet it is the diversity of the country that he is seeking to memorialise, even as he pursues it with the relentless zeal of a storyteller from the West, who's been told, keep it simple, soundbites should be short and instantly accessible.

He uses the classic mode of two brothers to tell his tale. One wonders again, whether there would have been such interest in sibling rivalry if there had been no Partition. No *Ram Aur Shyam*, no Ram-Rahim, no neat divisions into the left side of the brain and the right. Vassanji is far more subtle in his thesis, of course. He traces the ancestry of narrator Karsan Dargawalla all the way back to the 13th century, when a mysterious wanderer known as Nur Fazal Pir, evading the Mongol hordes of Hulagu Khan, arrived at the gates of Vishal Dev, who ruled the kingdom of Patan.

For the readers of the *Ras Mala*, this is a standard and, yes, absolutely mag-

MYTH MAGIC: The author takes us on a mystery tour of medieval India

ical mystery tour of medieval India, with its flying horses, ancient hags capable of ingesting serpents and divinely beautiful princesses bathing in ponds filled with the usual lotus flowers. Vassanji does the gorgeous Gujarat bit with all the enthusiasm of a tour operator taking Paris Hilton and party on a touchy reconnaissance of the region. It's both sensual and strange.

For the rest of us, he gives us the usual masala *chai* of odd characters—the kindly Sardar who drives a lorry and brings both colour and messages from the outside world to the sensitive young mind of Karsan; the teacher David, who gives him lessons in boxing, in Christianity and in the price that he has to pay for being different. There's also an elegantly drawn image of his father, Bapu, and the tenuous hold he has on Karsan, his older son, who will take on the mantle of the keeper of the sacred shrine of Pirbaag, the hereditary family legacy.

Maybe this loving, yet for the most part, stifling hold that Bapu has on him and which he seeks to escape by going to America and then to Canada, where Vassanji actually lives, is a metaphor of the price that every Indian ex-pat has to struggle to either renege or pay. What makes it utterly fascinating in this case is the idea that there may be a genetic disposition to mysticism, or what today, we may call a God gene, that manifests itself in certain persons, or may actually be cultivated in them. Vassanji is somewhat dogged in tracing these neural pathways in the mystical poetry of John Donne or Keats to what Bapu himself had tried to inculcate in Karsan.

He also introduces an element of historical mystery in the story of the Valley of the Assassins, a well-known bit of mythmaking from Persia that English scholars particularly enjoyed exploring, a little on the lines of our own *thuggee* tradition. It makes you wonder whether there is a killer gene lurking in our DNA. The character of the brother, who becomes involved in the post-Godhra events, might suggest this. Alas, aside from asking Karsan to bring him American blue jeans and shirts when he returns to India, he is so sketchily introduced that he may as well represent the survival of the killer blue jeans. ■